Three Places Families Get Stuck When Mom Needs Care and the Advice Doesn't Agree

What each one looks like, why it happens, and the habit that helps.

Most families in this spot get stuck in the same three places. None of them means you've done anything wrong, and each has a habit that helps.

1 Treating every piece of advice as settled

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE The business office says one thing at the front desk, a neighbor whose father went through this says another, and a website says a third. All three go onto the same mental list, and the most recent one tends to win.

WHY IT HAPPENS Each piece arrives sounding sure, and you have no way yet to tell them apart. The system behind them isn't simple: the federal Administration for Community Living describes long-term services as run through numerous funding streams and many agencies, and says Medicaid's eligibility rules and covered services vary from state to state. Advice that was right for another family may not fit Mom. [1] [2]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Write each piece down with who said it, when, and whether that person knows Mom's situation. Mark where two of them disagree. Each disagreement is a question to bring to your Medicaid planner. It isn't something you have to settle tonight.

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2 Working on every problem at once

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE In one evening you call the bank, read about Medicaid applications and look up attorneys, and none of it feels finished. Underneath is the question families ask most: what should we do first?

WHY IT HAPPENS Nobody has said what comes first, so everything looks equally pressing. There isn't a general order to look up, either. The Administration for Community Living says even the best time to apply depends on a person's medical situation, marital status and the complexity of their finances. [3]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Get three short summaries onto one page: Mom's care, her finances, and what you've been told about Medicaid. Then bring “what comes first?” to the planning conversation as a question. Sorting what happens now from what can wait is done there, with your Medicaid planner, from Mom's facts.

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3 Carrying a big decision alone while the bills keep coming

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE Another month's statement from the facility arrives, the plan still isn't clear, and moving money, selling something or signing something starts to feel like the responsible thing to do.

WHY IT HAPPENS Paying privately month after month is hard, and wanting to do something about it is natural. It is also a common place to begin: Medicare.gov says most people who enter nursing homes start by paying for their care out of pocket. [4]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Keep the record: what was paid, when, and from which account. Take any decision about money, property or a legal document to the professional it belongs to before acting on it. The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau's guide for people managing a relative's money says to get legal advice and be very careful about decisions that may affect a person's eligibility for Medicaid. [5]

The one habit behind all three

Write down what you know, what you've been told and who said it. Take each open question to the person it belongs to.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say which advice is right, what your family should do first, or what to do about the bills, and nothing in it is legal, financial or tax advice. It names three sticking points, the same three the Medicaid Planning Roadmap sees at this step.

Ready for the next step?

You know three habits that help while the plan is still unclear. The planning interview is the next step from here: it asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to your Medicaid planner, or to any other conversation about paying for care.

Get Your Free Planning Report ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The descriptions of the long-term care system, of Medicaid varying from state to state, of application timing and of how most nursing home stays are first paid for come from the sources below, as does the advice to get legal advice first. The three sticking points are the Medicaid Planning Roadmap's own.

1. Administration for Community Living, Aging and Disability Resource Centers Program/No Wrong Door System
2. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Medicaid
3. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Applying for Medicaid
4. Medicare.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), How can I pay for nursing home care?
5. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Managing someone else's money: Help for agents under a power of attorney

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